



Robotics startups folding

Robotic startups have a habit of crumbling despite having really good ideas and innovative products. <https://dgit.in/jun20-128>



Failed predictions from 2010

A roundup of big bets on technologies from the previous decade that didn't really hit the mark. <https://dgit.in/jun20-129>

FEATURE

wide web, and it flopped. Started in 1991, Gopher aimed to have simple syntax, make content searchable, and arrange files in a hierarchical manner. Sound familiar?

So what killed it? The University of Minnesota (UM) and CERN. UM is where gopher started, and thus, UM felt like they should be able to benefit from the popularity of a creation they'd facilitated. Although the code was everywhere already, in 1993, UM stated that they wanted to start charging licensing fees for the use of the gopher server code they were developing and maintaining. In contrast, as the World Wide Web took off, the place it had been developed was CERN and they made a clear statement to the world that they weren't interested in claiming ownership of the WWW. They just wanted those who would benefit from it to use it, and spread it as far and wide as possible. These two events meant that WWW spread like wildfire, and Gopher usage stagnated and started to decline. Even though UM released Gopher under the GNU license in 2000, it was already too late by then to ever mount a revival. Had just a few events not happened, today all of us might have been typing in gopher:// instead of http:// as we normally do. There are still millions of gopher servers online and being indexed by Veronica-2. If you're interested in reading more about gopher, write in and tell us, and we will write a much more indepth piece about it.

PALM TREO

The Palm Treo was one of the first touch and QWERTY hybrid smartphones, and was released in 2002, and was produced all the way until 2008. This writer owned the Palm Treo 650 GSM back in 2004, and felt like a rocket scientist! It was so advanced compared to the dumb phones that we were used to at the time, that one didn't feel important enough to be able to use all the features!



The Treo was the first smartphone

Simple things like storing multiple numbers for a single person seemed like revelations at the time, and the ability to create to-do lists, and it had a camera built into the phone... The QWERTY pad made messaging a snap, and it boasted of 23 MB of space to store things in, plus SD card support! Most importantly, however, the thing could store as many phonebook entries as memory would allow, which was waaaaay more than the dumbphones allowed at the time. Using the Treo would immediately open up your eyes to the possibility of what the future held for us. And boy did that future turn out to be one dominated by smartphones!

CELESTRON

Amongst others, Celestron is deemed to be one of the brands that kickstarted amateur astronomy for the masses. They developed a method of manufacturing telescopes that were very capable, but for very affordable prices, which made it accessible to hundreds of thousands of more people.

Founded in 1964, Celestron first mass produced the C8 (8-inch diameter) Schmidt-Cassegrain telescope, which is a type of telescope that uses a reflector to essentially halve the length of telescope required for a given focal length, thus making it ideal for amateur users who want to carry it around everywhere they go.

While the company itself went in and out of bankruptcy, being bought and sold several times over the years, Celestron is still the brand that many

Gen X kids know of, as it was probably the first telescope they looked through, at home, in school or at a friend's place.

MICROSOFT SPOT

If you think the Apple products are cool, it's only because you have never heard of Microsoft's SPOT. Smart Personal Objects Technology (SPOT) was an initiative that Microsoft started to make smart

appliances and gadgets. Bill Gates launched the idea in 2002, which was to convert all gadgets and gizmos around the house and carried on your person into smart devices with screens that could do more than just read out settings of the device itself. So, you could expect to see a coffee maker that told you the weather forecast for the day while you brew your coffee in the morning. Since wireless networks



A Suunto smartwatch from 2004 based on Microsoft SPOT

were not as ubiquitous in 2002, SPOT used FM subcarrier transmission (the same way in which your car deck gets data about the song it is playing on FM) to understand and show relevant data. Sadly, as with so many things Microsoft, they tried to make it a subscription model, which people hated. Plus, it was the time when Microsoft hate was rampant. If only we knew then what we do now, we might actually consider Microsoft to be the lesser of the evils that followed...

HYPERCARD

Released in 1987, but imagined by Bill Atkinson around 1984, as he was tripping on some LSD, HyperCard was given to Apple by Atkinson, with the understanding that it would be offered for free to all buyers of Apple products. On its own, for non-Apple devices, it was sold for \$49.95. It was kind of like the web, before the actual web became a thing. Using a programming language called HyperTalk, HyperCard was a simple flat-database application with source code exposed, and was essentially like a rolodex, and had a stack of cards that could be